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Dick Hyman Part II

In the six years since his first interview for the Archive, Dick Hyman has maintained a steady pace of quality musical endeavors. He produces the summer jazz concerts at New York City's 92nd Street Y, performs at numerous jazz festivals, scores film music, and records for the Arbors record label. Mr. Hyman will receive an honorary degree from Hamilton College in May of 2002.

Part II was conducted in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 17, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Clearwater Beach. I'm very pleased to have Dick Hyman with me again today. And this is a real pleasure, first of all just to talk to you, but also because you were my first interview.

DH: Was I the first?

MR: You were the very first.

DH: What year was that?

MR: That was March '95 in Scottsdale, Arizona.

DH: Yeah. Well I remember it and of course I've seen it, you were kind enough to give me a copy that I saw only recently actually.

MR: I know you have not been idle in the last six years.

DH: No. Do you want a recount?

MR: Well I'd like to talk about a couple of things. First of all I recently saw the latest Woody Allen film and I thought that was a great piece of work.

DH: Well thank you. Everybody has enjoyed that film and paid more attention to it really than some of the earlier ones in which I worked far harder. There's a lot more to do on "Everyone Says I Love You," than on this one. This one was mostly Howard, Howard Alden. He did a marvelous job. And mainly these things were pre-recorded and Howard taught Sean Penn to mime his playing very well. And so this had very few of the problems that you usually have of putting music in afterwards. It's easier if you do it in front and the film adapts to what you did.

MR: I see. We should — for people who might watch this — we should say we're talking about "Sweet and Low Down."

DH: "Sweet and Low Down."

MR: Yeah. Did you like the script?

DH: I thought it was very funny and strangely true to life. I've known several people like this. I've known guys who reminded me strongly of that Emmett Ray, and I'd better not name them.

MR: Yeah. He kind of had all his eggs in one basket you know, so musical but a little short on the social skills and all that.

DH: Well, yeah.

MR: What's Woody Allen like to collaborate with?

DH: Well if I had to characterize it in a particular way I'd say knowledgeable, musically. He knows music. He picks the tunes. He's open to suggestion and it's easy to work with him, as opposed to some people who don't know very much about the subject at all and may still give you a hard time. But the people who know that they don't know about the subject, they're okay to work with, they leave it to you. Woody is both. Woody leaves it to me and to the other people, I presume, the costumers and the set designers and so forth, but he has certain specific ideas and in the case of music he knows quite a bit on his own, so we've always gotten along pretty well.

MR: When you're doing a tune for a movie that's not nearly as music-specific, and you have to do background things for certain scenes, how does that music evolve? Is it his suggestion of songs or is it—

DH: Well it's all different ways. If the background music is to be a specific song, why of course Woody and I will have talked about it beforehand and then it becomes a matter of arranging it according to what's needed in the scene. If it's original music I go to my piano and work out some ideas, probably would run them by Woody in advance. And the mathematics of it is the interesting part, and the difficult part — more difficult really than composing the music. The mathematics of writing to the requirements of the dimensions of the film and the interior events of a scene require that you really work things out beat by beat over the span of a cue which might be anywhere typically from a minute to maybe three minutes long. So that's fun too. By now I know how to do that and I first began to learn how to do that when I was doing television spots — commercials — which in many ways are miniature movies. You practice all your skills within 58 seconds, which was the norm as it used to be. Now I don't see many minute spots anymore, they're mostly down to about 15 seconds.

MR: Yeah, I've noticed that watching some of the stations that have the re-runs and all that, it seems very odd to see a full minute commercial now.

DH: I think that's something out of the past, but that was the norm. And then 30 second ones were — commonly you'd do a 60 second and a 30 second. But when you say 60 seconds it always meant 58 because of some technical requirements of getting things going. In the beginning you couldn't ever start the sound before about a second and a half of time had gone by, so they came to be known as 58 second spots. But what I know, if I know anything, I've really learned from those tiny little dramas. And some of them were very ambitious in their way. Some of them have plots and emotional points and so forth.

MR: Would you get like a storyboard or something?

DH: Well yeah. You get a storyboard and you come up with an idea and you try out the music on the client. One time I was working for Herman Edel Associates, Herman Edel that is, and we had a meeting with a client and we both thought we understood the client explicitly. We thought we knew exactly what he wanted. And I improvised some music on the keyboard and the client said fine and I said okay I'll arrange it and we'll do the date tomorrow. These things can be done rather fast if you know how to do it. And we got into the studio and we ran it down with the combo, and the client said, "that's not what I had in mind at all," which was a terrible blow — not what you had in mind at all. But in such a case you tried to adjust. You don't want to change the rhythm because then the time will all be wrong. But you say well we'll try it on a different instrument, and we would ask Phil Bodner, the all-around doubler, don't play on an alto sax, play it on flute, and the client still didn't like whatever little adjustments we were able to make. Finally we had to give up and go home and re-write it. That happens rarely but it can happen. I came to understand that in that business, all of the drama was on the other side of the glass of the control room. Where we were, we could run it down once and be ready to go and that's all there was to it. On the other side they were jockeying for position. They were really jockeying for the status so as not to be blamed in case the man up on high didn't like it. They had to be carefully dividing up the responsibility — the blame that is. And that's where it was all happening. That's where the drama was.

MR: That's really interesting. Who were the players behind the glass?

DH: Well behind the glass we would have my friend Herman Edel, who ran this company which hired the services of me and other composer/arrangers/conductors, and then there would be the account executive, the guy or woman who was in charge of that particular product, and then there would be somebody superior to that person in the agency, and then maybe even a little later on at a fashionably late time just after you thought everything was going well, about three-quarters of an hour into the session, the real Mr. Big would step in and tell you that's not what I had in mind at all. So I learned a lot about how the game works after a time. Of course I had been playing those commercials for years, I knew very much about the playing side of it, but I hadn't understood all the devious political game playing that was going on on the other side of the glass.

MR: Yeah, it must have been some jockeying because they probably want to take credit for it if it works.

DH: They want to take credit, and they don't want to take blame. But it's kind of funny.

MR: Can you rattle off a few of the commercials you remember doing, specific things?

DH: Well it was so long ago that some of them are now illicit. For example we used to do cigarette ads. I can't remember them now. Too many products. When I was working with

Herman and then after that for a year or so I had my own firm going in partnership with a fellow named Frank Garisto, and we would do one or two of these a week. It was fairly good money and it was kind of interesting and as I say the strain was in dealing with the client and not in producing the music.

MR: And you had top guys playing on the sessions, right?

DH: Well yeah. Well now you're getting into the studio scene in New York, which I was lucky enough to get into in the 1950s and stayed with into the 1980s. There were several hundred, as I estimate, it couldn't have been more than maybe two hundred people who did most of the recording work in New York and by recording I mean not only the commercials for dozens of producers around town, but the phonograph records, which were all ad hoc kind of orchestras — Andre Kostelanetz, Percy Faith, those were typical of the upper end of things you might say. And the rock 'n rollers, which you might say was the lower end, we worked for them too. And then there were the film people because films — a small number comparatively — of films were scored in New York and composers would pick up a band to do that. But when I say pick up a band, this is not just saying any old guy off the street could come in and do this, it was very specialized work and all of these people, of whom I'm proud to say I was one, could really do any number of jobs that were called on. I'm talking about people like Phil Bodner say, the reed player, Bernie Glow, trumpeter, Mel Davis, Doc Severinsen, before he became his own conductor of course. Al Caiola the guitarist, Tony Motolla, Bobby Rosengarden, Milt Hinton, George Duvivier, goodness, Bill Lavorgna before he became the conductor for Liza Minelli was a hell of a good studio drummer. And my colleagues in the piano department were Bernie Leighton, Moe Wexler early on, but then he got out of it quite early was Lou Stein, Hank Jones. Then there were the string players by the dozens. Arnold Itis, David Madien.

MR: So if you were listening to Andrew Kostelanetz, and then you listened to Percy Faith —

DH: It was liable to be the same orchestra. Yes. And well the rock 'n roll groups also were liable to have the same people, it was a slightly different cast, but I learned that the more things one could do, the more gigs you'd be called on, so I could change hats, all of us could really, and start being funky and play for Atlantic Records in the evening, and do Kostelanetz in the morning and somebody else in-between.

MR: That's so cool. Let's talk about this. Because I went back and was reading your first interview actually and you mentioned some of the people you played with — Ruth Brown and the Coasters and the Drifters. And you made a comment about their version of "White Christmas."

DH: Oh yeah. That was a session we did "White Christmas" — was that the Drifters or the Coasters?

MR: I think it was the Drifters.

DH: Yeah, I believe you're right. The session included Jerry Wexler, who is a good friend of mine in Florida, he's long retired, he points out that that session with the Drifters produced four hits. Not only "White Christmas" but "The Bells of St. Mary," and two others which I can't name. In those days you know, it was customary to do four numbers in a session. Now people take a month to do something and they track it and they change it and they mess around with it. Well the union contract specified four numbers in three hours. And many people did just that, even in pop records, or maybe you'd go into a half hour or an hour overtime, but four tunes was the norm. At any rate there was always something going on and I loved it.

MR: You had said that. "we said to each other at that time in twenty years" — this was 1955 or so — "in twenty years people will say to each other 'listen darling, they're playing our song.' You know that's exactly what happened. All that funny music that we laughed at became classic rock."

DH: That's true. That's absolutely true. We've all lived to see that. When I see now the musicology that's spent on early rock 'n roll and the nostalgia and the way it's permeated everything we do I just marvel at it. In those days we didn't really respect it much. We just did it.

MR: But what kind of adjustment was there for players who were let's say swing oriented, to start playing that different style? Was it a big deal?

DH: Well yes and no. As Milt Hinton used to say "yes and then again, no." Of course there were adjustments to be made. Rock 'n roll was a blues style basically and I knew what to do I think because I had grown up with a lot of blues and boogie woogie piano records by Meade Lux Lewis and Albert Ammons and Pete Johnson and all those people. And so it wasn't all that remarkable to figure out how to play along with some of those people. And many of them really were blues singers. Then there was another kind of rock 'n roll which came about soon after that. People weren't blues singers at all. They were people like Jill Corey for example, just to name one that I remember. Pop singers, in other words, for whom it became customary to play a very formularized background. The pianist would always play triplets. High triplets that would go to Mars and back again [scats]. And now and then we would give it a more bracing style of playing eighth notes. And Frankie Avalon for example. Did I say this when we —

MR: No you didn't talk about Frankie.

DH: Frankie Avalon was the center of a bunch of artists from Philadelphia whom Al Caiola got to be the contractor for. Chancellor Records. They would come to town and do sessions with bands that Al booked. And the drummer was liable to be Panama Francis or Gary Chester. Al would play — the second guitar would likely to be Don Arnone or Al

Cassamenti. There was always a honking saxophone. Sam "The Man" Taylor had the monopoly on that for some time, but also a fella named Buddy Lucas, well that was a different company. If Sam wasn't around then — a fella who died just last year, a very good saxophonist —

MR: Jerome Richardson?

DH: Jerome was another one. Absolutely Jerome, but I was thinking of a third fellow. Had a slightly odd name. It will come to us. Jerome was another guy. Jerome was another very good all around player too. He could honk like crazy if that was necessary but he played good jazz on several saxophones, he could read perfectly and he played flute, he played jazz flute. So people like that could fit into sections. There were a couple of others who were just great blues soloists who you really wouldn't want to hire in a big band to do any considerable reading or non-jazz, non-blues kind of stuff. Jerome could do that. The fun thing about it was that we would hire each other. I might work for Caiola at one point during the day and he would work for me somewhere else, then we'd both work for a third party on other date. We'd meet each other coming and going all over town, and playing wildly different kind of music. And the game was you rarely were consulted in advance as to what was going to be taking place. If it was a very special and maybe virtuoso situation or the arranger had some other reason to get a little anxious about it, you might be consulted and maybe given some music to look at but that was rare. Usually you just walked into the date and tried to figure out what was going on and lit into it. It was great fun but at the same time there were dates that were so boring that you could literally close your eyes and go to sleep and there were others that were terrifyingly difficult. Occasionally I came on some film score, I remember distinctly there was a very accomplished composer/writer named Frank Lewin who did the music for several different programs and one of them that I remember was called "The Nurses." This would have been in the late '50s or early '60s. And he wrote — it had nothing to do with jazz what he wrote. He just wrote very, very — how shall I describe it? Schoenberg maybe. Sort of like that. It required great reading skills and I remember those were dates you didn't fall asleep on.

MR: The typical part you'd get on a pop session, did it have chord symbols and just an indication of what to do?

DH: Yeah. Even, this is the strange thing, that in most situations even if the rest of the band was highly organized, the piano part was really almost always an automatic copying job in which you really reading the bass part and the guitar part and being encouraged to do what was necessary. The piano player would figure out what I call the in-betweens. If it was a swing kind of thing you'd put in Count Basie things here and there. And in other cases it might be that you should be playing in two or playing in four, maybe playing the

part exactly the way it was with no fill-ins, and sometimes there are some wide open opportunities to do something that the arranger hadn't thought of. And if you were diplomatic about it he might appreciate very much if you gave a slightly different cast to what he wanted.

MR: Were you hearing the vocals, the way these things were recorded?

DH: Well formerly yes, but then came the custom of enclosing the vocalist in a chamber altogether so that he or she could do it over again later. You would ask the engineer in that case. Yes, you would have to hear the vocal. There were times, however, and I thought it was kind of poor planning, when the singer wasn't even around and he didn't know what it was going to be. And in those cases you did the best you could. But the ideal thing was for the rhythm section to hear the vocal so that they could put in anything that seemed appropriate.

MR: Right. Or not appropriate.

DH: Or inappropriate, yeah. But of course there were other dates too in which things were quite closely written out. And those you read. Sometimes you adjusted them a little bit and generally arrangers appreciated if you suggested you could play something in a different octave or double it or something like that. We were friends with the arrangers and all of them understood that we too were arrangers. So there wasn't a competition there. And everybody tried to do the right thing.

MR: Who were some of those names? Would we recognize the names?

DH: The arrangers?

MR: Yeah.

DH: Well besides Percy Faith for example, Ray Ellis was really my connection for a lot of the rock 'n roll things. He arranged for Atlantic and he arranged for Columbia for people like I think it was the Four Freshmen. And he did a lot of different things. Generally if you got an association going with an arranger you would follow him to play for all the different labels for which he was getting his jobs. So we would get to know every studio and every combination. Well let's see if I can think of some others in addition to Ray. Dave Terry was a very good arranger and he did charts for Joanie James among others.

MR: Not Quincy Jones?

DH: Quincy would come to town now and then, yes. Quincy of course we did things for him that were often more interesting than some of the other people. They had more jazz content. Quincy actually worked often with the man who scored his ideas who was the actual arranger, well depending on how you defined it, and that was Billy Byers. Sometimes you know there's a division of labor, especially in California. The composer will do a score up to a certain point and then an orchestrator will take over. And Billy it

was said did that sort of thing for Quincy. Let me see if I can think of some other arrangers. They'll all come to me after we finish.

MR: Well maybe we'll have to do Part III.

DH: Oh, I'll give you a few more. Jimmy Carroll was an associate of Mitch Miller. He not only did sing-a-longs, "Sing-A-Long with Mitch," which we pre-recorded and occasionally go trapped into being on camera for, but he did a lot of the other pop dates, including, I don't know why I thought of it Doug Gelcoury who I mentioned before, and all sorts of people who came into Columbia under Mitch Miller's reign. I'll think of a few more, I'll interrupt you.

MR: And you guys who played on these things, you didn't get a piece of the record did you?

DH: No. No, no.

MR: You just got the union scale?

DH: Well after a while there was something that was instituted which did in effect give us a piece of the record, the number, there was a formula that finally the record companies and the union agreed on which was based on the number of dates annually that a particular player did for a particular record company. And that was put into a trust and the trust was divided among the musicians. Something like that. But no, we never got a specific royalty arrangement. Some of us were fortunate enough to be artists for one company or another and then you would get a royalty arrangement and occasionally we would compose things and then be the composer and possibly the publisher. So that was another way. But generally the sidemen would not. And generally too the arranger would not. The arranger was paid a price and usually it was nothing to do with the royalty.

MR: So if you listened to — I don't know if you ever sit and listen to the oldies station —

DH: I do.

MR: Are you likely to hear yourself?

DH: Very much.

MR: And do you remember —

DH: Yeah, I remember some.

MR: Can you tell me a couple of spots that I might hear?

DH: Yeah. Johnny Mathis, there's one — there's a famous Mathis record that begins with a piano figure. "Chances Are."

MR: "Chances Are." Yes. That's you?

DH: That's one. Yeah. And then there's another one that I whistled on for Johnny Mathis. [whistles]

MR: [hums].

DH: That's right. And there's another Bob Allen song.

MR: "Wonderful Wonderful."

DH: Right.

MR: That's you whistling is that right?

DH: That was one of my — well you know I had made my own — I have to admit — hit record of "Moritat," which then became known as "Theme from the Three Penny Opera" and then finally became known as "Mack the Knife" in 1955 for MGM as the Dick Hyman Trio which actually had four people in it I think. And I whistled on it as well as playing an instrument called the harpsichord piano. So it became known around town that I was willing and I was capable of whistling. Willing to undertake it and capable of doing it without running out of breath. So I found myself being called to be a whistler on dates and I promptly joined AFTRA, that is the singers union, because their scale was higher than the musician's union, and on a good day I might collect both scales on a single session. So I'm the whistler on that and I'm the whistler on something with Nye and Marlowe for Archie Bleier's company Cadence, something called "The Man in the Raincoat," one of those spooky "Third Man" theme type recordings.

MR: Was it a lip whistle or was it a teeth whistle?

DH: No, no, no. The teeth whistling we left to Bob Haggart.

MR: Oh, of course.

DH: No, it was regular whistling. And I did a fair number of those things and they are very funny to think about now. After a while I dropped or suspended my membership in AFTRA.

MR: That's great. I love hearing that stuff. I mean you did, you know people think of you as someone who can do anything.

DH: I've done my best. I know it's not true. I know quite a few things I can't do. But I was willing to try almost anything. Another time, well I was, well I look at it now that I've become a kind of elder curmudgeon, when I look back at it I was amazingly cooperative and supportive in those days. And if the percussion section seemed to be short one effect or another I would jump in and play claves or maracas or other Latin sort of things. And one time Mitch Miller needed something or other which involved slapping your hands on your thighs like [slaps] and don't you know I volunteered to do that. And I gave myself terrible bruises after recording some number that I certainly don't recall the name of.

MR: I don't suppose you could hit up AFTRA for workman's comp.

DH: But also keyboardists were expected to double on all sorts of instruments. And that's why I became an organist really. And I played, at times I played more organ than I did piano. And sometimes went back and forth in the same session or even on the same number that we played celeste. And we played various electronic things like a Fender piano and a couple of other weird things that were fashionable for a few months.

MR: And that was high tech at the time, right?

DH: Yeah.

MR: Those things?

DH: Yeah. And I got into being able to play a very limited amount of mallet instruments too if they were needed, you know I could help out on a xylophone or some of the other strange instruments that might have been special effects devices rampant from carol music, things that looked like a picket fence and made funny boing noises and all that. I was fascinated by the percussion section and I hung around with Phil Crouse, the leading guy in town, enough to get the hang of some of this. And you see I was able to use all that knowledge I picked up in my own arrangements. So the whole thing was quite interactive, you might even say incestuous. We all hired each other, worked on each other's dates and learned from each other. It was a time when arrangers would call up players and ask to be informed about the ranges of instruments or the nature of some new gadget that you might be using, or whether something was playable or not. I did it myself and people called me and asked me about things having to do with the Lowry organ or whatever. It was a community of people who would help each other out.

MR: What changed it?

DH: In my case I realized that I ought to be getting out because I found I was competing with myself. I couldn't be hoping to be the arranger/conductor in charge of things and then hiring myself out as anybody's piano player. I managed to do that for about twenty years just that — sitting on the fence really. And once or twice being embarrassed by the dual role but not often. But after a while I realized it was counterproductive to do that and I was more interested in doing my own things and I had really to make a choice. So I began to make that choice whenever I could and gradually. Gradually it happened that finally I was willing to leave New York altogether and just return for my own things when needed. Also by that time I had become much more interested in becoming a concert performer than I ever was in the early days I was speaking about. So the concert things and the specific calls to arrange and compose were more important than just being a very busy piano player or keyboard player. But I still do dates as a sideman occasionally for friends.

MR: I brought in a couple of examples of some of your own things, and maybe you can comment on how this came about and —

[audio interlude]

DH: Well the Jelly Roll Morton album for Columbia was Sam Parkins' idea, the producer. And he thought, and he got Columbia to think, that with the unexpected popularity of Scott Joplin from the movie "The Sting" and the various recordings, including my own, that perhaps Jelly Roll Morton would be the next on the list and that's why we did that album. And we did it with several components. We did it like that record of "Grandpa's

Spells" like that track of "Grandpa's Spells" with a big band. It was my idea to make it like to a big concert marching band and that's the way I arranged those things. We also did some smaller bands and we also did a couple of things as a trio with Joe Venuti — Panama Francis and Venuti and I. In fact Jelly Roll Morton did not become the next pop hit after Scott Joplin and I think the record has never paid for itself.

MR: Oh okay.

DH: So much for predictions. They did re-issue that and the following James P. Johnson album as one CD which is now available. But now I think even that's been cut out.

MR: Oh. It's a great sound. There's some challenging parts in there too.

DH: Yeah. And I occasionally use those arrangements now for live concerts. They work well say for a college band or something. So I pull them out and I do them live.

MR: Okay. Here's another thing.

[audio interlude]

DH: Well this is the next album that I mentioned, the James P. Johnson album. God damn that's fast.

MR: I know. In fact I was going to ask you if you'd like to admit on tape that you sped this up after you recorded it?

DH: No.

MR: It sounds impossible to me.

DH: Well no, now that I think about it, this is not the James P. Johnson album, this is the "Enoch Light Company."

MR: This is off this.

DH: No I don't think so. This is from that album. This is from the "Enoch Light" album. No it's not sped up and it's too fast. One thing I've learned about these things is that, and I think all young people that become old people learn it after a while, is that speed is not the point. You should learn to slow them down so they swing more later on. I went back and re-learned "Carolina Shout" from Johnson's original recording, and after I'd been playing it too fast for many years, and I learned that it should be done at a nice, comfortable, tap-dance tempo. This sure does sound like a sped up piano roll but that's really not the goal. What else have you got?

MR: I've got, actually after this comes a recent thing with Ruby.

DH: This is "Keep Off the Grass" isn't it? Yeah it is. Do you know all through this time of recording the Johnson and Morton pieces, I had a Sunday night job at The Cookery in Greenwich Village. And I really worked on these. That's why that sounds so good. You have to be playing in a club setting at least once a week, which was all I was able to do, in order to be able to manage that kind of thing.

MR: You said a moment ago that you learned some pieces need to be slowed down so they can swing. Is it possible to define what makes things swing?

DH: No. It's not possible. It's not possible. It either swings or it doesn't swing. But the right tempo is certainly the way to accomplish it. What the right tempo is is a matter of great debate and trial and error. I'm interested in one thing though. When I listen to, well even as far back as disco and now in terms of rap music, they really have learned mathematically what the tempos are that swing. And when DJs program things and when the records are made in the first place, I believe that they know which numbers on the metronome are the ones that will swing. And so there is a possibility mathematically of figuring that out. I've never gotten into it myself but I believe that that's what programmers do. And I believe also that the records that they use have the tempos calibrated so that they can move from one to the other with identical or perhaps slightly increasing tempos in order to get the crowd moving.

MR: Yeah. It must have something to do with how comfortably people can physically move.

DH: Well it has to do with that, and also it has to do — the best theory I've ever heard has to do with the normal rate of a heartbeat. That is what I think normal march tempo is, 120, which is [scats] about that. That's I believe the normal heart rate. These are psychological and medical ideas which probably you could explore a lot more.

MR: Let me throw — I had another question also about trying to define hard things — and that is the concept of what you choose to play when you're improvising.

DH: Oh. You mean what piece or what ideas?

MR: No. Where does improvising come from?

DH: It comes from your background and from the ideas of whomever you may be playing with, and also your technical capability. The ideas of — I've used this analogy before — the ideas are rather like a kaleidoscope which you shake up so that it produces different images each time but they're made up of the same colored jewels and bits of paper. They are liable to be the same ideas in a different form every time you shake it up unless you keep adding to the kaleidoscope and put in different jewels, different colored pieces of paper, and then when you shake it up the next time it's going to be a bit different. But there is very little, I think, of improvisation that hasn't been thought of before or that you haven't somehow used. The point is to keep replenishing the supply and keep on mixing it up differently. And a way that you can — certainly the tool that you use is just technique. If I'm in good shape technically I will try things that I wouldn't otherwise. If I'm not in shape technically I won't try to do certain things, I'll stay where it's safe and I know that I've been before. But if I feel very loose and in good shape and I've played a lot then I really can stretch out and try things that maybe I've heard other people do and see if I can get my version of, try things, just let the fingers go where they may, and pose

certain problems for myself and see how I can get out of them, and just sometimes there are, too, moments where you don't quite know where an idea comes from. Those are precious and they're rare. If you're lucky you're recording them or you can write them down and they become compositions. But you watch for those. Sometimes you can chase them. If you have to compose something on a deadline of course, you really go out and you try to grab the muse and bring her back. Sometimes you can be successful. Some people use drugs and liquor to get to that stage. I'm not sure that works. I do think that, in my case, in the first part of the day might be the most creative part, and that possibly is because I've been thinking about the things through the night that I want to get to the next day.

MR: You bring up an interesting point with liquor and so forth. It seems to have an unfortunate connection with jazz music anyway. Do you have any thoughts on why?

DH: Well I don't think, I really don't think smoking pot and worse are creative inspirations. I don't think that's how it works at all. I do think sometimes people may be less inhibited and they can release things that are there all the time, but I don't think those drugs bring on, I don't think they're the bearers of inspiration. They can let things come out that you might be too uptight to release.

MR: Yeah. I remember reading an annoying article once and the writer was basically saying that Charlie Parker would not have been able to play what he did if he hadn't been on heroin.

DH: I don't know the answer to that. I just don't know. I do know that there are on records certain magical moments in various people's solos where you can only say to yourself where did that come from? You find it on early Armstrong, you find it on Bird's things. But not everything that Bird did. A good deal of what Bird played was enough of a rote so that players ever since have been able to sound very much like him because he did repeat his riffs. Every now and then. I've heard it also in some of Beiderbecke's solos. I've heard it in — I heard it not long ago and I was surprised because I hadn't really thought about him that way, in Django Reinhardt. Some of his solos. He suddenly goes into something, and it's beautiful, and it's so free and unencumbered by any rote playing. We all do rote playing. That's what I was trying to express before. It's the vocabulary that you play with. You try to increase your vocabulary. And now and then you can break out of it and do something and truly say where did that come from. Those are the moments you live for.

MR: Right. You started to mention a couple of people and I had a couple of names I was just going to throw at you, for maybe a short comment. Milt Hinton.

DH: Oh. What can I say that everybody else hasn't been saying about Milt since he passed? I did so many things with Milt that it's hard for me to cite any one experience. I do — no I

can think of one. [Thanks very much.] Some jazz party like this, I don't know, it wasn't this one but I can't remember where it was, Milt played a fast thing and I was playing in the rhythm section. And we got it going so perfectly. You know rhythm sections that are put together, as jazz parties do, catch as catch can, sometimes they work and sometimes they work less well. And one of them that worked so well that I was just terribly pleased to be a part of it was one with Milt and I don't remember who the drummer was. But in that case it was exactly the right tempo and Milt had exactly the right feeling going, his ideas were exactly right, his volume was exactly right. You know sometimes people, including Milt, would play too loud. Bassists sometimes do that because it's so easy as we say to turn the knob to the right that they sometimes play too loud for a rhythm section. Milt was exactly right. The piano was amplified correctly, the drummer was right on, and it went on for a very long time at a pretty brisk tempo and Milt never faltered. Some bassists have to leave out a note now and then because they can't really sustain something that goes on like that for a long time. It was just so wonderful. It must have gone on for about nine or ten minutes with all the solos. That was just one thing. I could always count on Milt to play anything I wrote and to embellish it and to make it much better than what I'd written. I always assumed that he would do that. There are other bass players too that I had a very warm relationship with. George Duvivier was the other fella. Bob Haggart was another. These are all guys who could, on their own, complement what you were doing and make something emerge that was bigger than the rhythm section.

MR: You know speaking of rhythm sections with Milt, if I had to do the classic what albums would I take if I were stuck on a beach somewhere, preferably this beach, one would be "The Age of Swing" that album you did. Because even that first tune, which I kind of assumed was rather improvised —

DH: I don't remember.

MR: It was just a blues.

DH: Oh yes. We called it "From the Age of Swing" and we had two takes on it.

MR: It's so perfect to me. It's so perfect that if I had to play something, here's an example of it.

DH: Speaking about Milt though, unfortunately he was a little bit under-recorded on that album. It was done by a company which prides itself on doing things in natural sound without enhancing anything later on or even at the time, and Milt was not, I doubt if he was playing with an amplifier. I've always felt that unless you compensate a little bit as you play the record, he's just a little bit under. But at any rate, yes, and the way that happened was that I asked Butch to get us going with a nice Count Basie tempo.

MR: There you go.

DH: And that's where it began. And of all the people I know that I could be playing with they're all there for this kind of nice, Count Basie tempo. And that was with Butch and Milt and Bucky. Bucky, who is certainly the best rhythm guitarist I've ever played with, he understands time in the same way that Butch and Milt do. And all I did was coast on top of them. We made two takes and they were both so good that we used the first one to open the album and the last one to close it. I'm glad you like it. Thank you.

MR: Yeah. And you talk about Bucky, he has this ability too to put the right note on top of his strumming.

DH: Well, you are so right. This is what he learned, I'm sure he would tell you this, from Freddie Green. There's something about the voicing that is right, and you know it when you hear it.

MR: How about Thelonious Monk?

DH: I don't like his piano playing at all. It makes me very anxious and angry. But I do value his compositions. And I understand and I value his freedom, his license you might say, but I do not like, as a pianist, and I never wanted to say it much while Thelonious was still around, I can't stand the way he plays. And there's one other person at least, a piano player who would agree with me, but we know we're against the tide, Roger Kellaway. There's a record of Thelonious that just, it's like somebody scratching chalk on a blackboard, that's "I Should Care." I never want to hear it again. But a great man. A great man in his way, just don't let me hear him playing his own tunes.

MR: All right. That's interesting. Speaking of that I'd love to hear you and Roger play together.

DH: We have an unreleased record that we did and it's terrific. It's really very good, that we made in The Bakery last year in L.A. I presume it will be put out someday. We were paid for it, and the idea was that the promoters would find a record company for that and two other albums with two other sets of pianists that they also produced. So I'm looking for that to come out. It's the best thing that Roger and I have done I think.

MR: How about Ken Burns?

DH: Oh you don't need my commentary on Ken Burns. I've read everything that's floating around on the Web and various other magazine and newspaper articles. I think it's marvelous that there is such a thing and that the publicity has been given to jazz to a degree that none of us ever would have expected. And it's marvelous that I can stand up to a concert audience now and assume they've seen the show and I can say I'm going to play something which you might have heard on the Ken Burns show whenever they were talking about Kansas City and Count Basie, I use this little riff, "Jumpin' at the Woodside." I wouldn't have done that in the past, but I know people now know who Basie and Armstrong and Ellington and Bix Beiderbecke and so forth were. People are

much more sympathetic now than they were. Much more educated. And that's wonderful. But the program, the series is not without its flaws and the basic flaw is that some remarkably important people were not included. And some people were mentioned and then nothing more was said of them. This is amazing. Unless I blinked I hardly saw anything about Oscar Peterson and I know there was only a brief mention of Bill Evans and Benny Carter was hardly mentioned, although I understand he was interviewed but somehow his interview wasn't used. So those are the things that are wrong. But given a subject of such vast depth and complexity and such great coverage you could hardly expect anybody would agree as to who might have been favored more and disfavored, I understand that too.

MR: Yeah. Well of course you make it in almost all those things because of your participation in, it was the only clip of Charlie Parker, right?

DH: Oh well yeah. I wasn't very pleased that they cut out my piano solo. They cut out the piano solo and they didn't say who was in the band. In fact I was there slightly to the left of Parker, as I say if you didn't blink then you could see the side of my head for about one and a half seconds.

MR: That's pretty amazing that's the only piece.

DH: Well you know there is this other one too which they showed.

MR: Yeah. From Japan or something.

DH: Yeah. The one from Japan is not a true film of Parker. We see him playing and we hear him playing but they're not the same. Obviously they mimed to pre-recorded stuff, or else maybe they put the music in after the video I'm not sure.

MR: Yeah. You can really tell if you're watching him. It's like this is a weird thing to do. Well this has been a great conversation again. Just to wrap up, you've seen jazz — jazz changes so fast, it's just amazing.

DH: Well it does.

MR: And I just wonder where is it going? How can it keep changing so fast? Do you have any opinions on what's going to happen with it? When I look at this jazz party scene, it's really wonderful to be at, I wonder how long it can keep going.

DH: One of the most remarkable things about this party is the way that Mat [Domber] has been including women. And that bass player, what's her name, Parrott, Vicky is her name?

MR: Nicki?

DH: Nicki Parrott. Wonderful — and I saw the saxophonist is that Strassmayer?

MR: Yeah.

DH: Karol Strassmayer. She was terrific last night. And the drummer.

MR: Sherrie.

DH: Sherrie Maricle. Terrific. I realize that really we have been neglecting a great resource. And this is the first party, the first casting I've seen in which these terrific players are represented without being an all-girl band and which is kind of an insulting thing anyhow. So I'm happy to see that. Where the music is going I don't know. Who can possibly say? I find that I'm less interested in such conjectures and just trying to concentrate on where I'm going.

MR: Okay.

DH: Now that I've reached the mature age of 74. Ruby's [Braff] birthday and mine are very close you know, and a few people are, I was very touched last year when James Williams and what's his name Childs, the other pianist.

MR: Billy Childs?

DH: Billy Childs. They called me up together and wished me a happy birthday and informed me that their birthdays are the same. This was very nice. At any rate so we've formed a birthday club and now they tell me that George Coleman is also a March 8.

MR: Well you're in good company then.

DH: Yeah.

MR: Well thanks again for your time and I look forward to your next visit to Hamilton for your degree.

DH: Well I'm looking forward to that. I absolutely am looking forward to receiving that degree. And I'm sure we'll talk before then.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Thanks so much.